

COARA ACTION PLAN

Roadmap towards the implementation of the
CoARA principles



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Introduction

In line with the founding spirit of CoARA (Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment which UNIME joined in 2022), the University of Messina has begun a path of renewal of the research evaluation processes and procedures. New recruitment and financing strategies have been put in place aimed at valorizing the researcher resources within the University.

The University of Messina (UNIME), in agreement with the CoARA principles, recognizes in particular the importance of an accurate academic career assessment (ACA) system, with bias mitigation, that suitably evaluates the academic staff performance and fosters a culture of research quality, open science and data sharing.

This action plan, in the first phase of application of the CoARA roadmap, outlines a comprehensive approach at UNIME to reforming academic career assessment towards an inclusive evaluation of research, focusing on quality assessment principles

Background

The University of Messina is committed to open science principles, promoting transparency, accessibility, reproducibility and equity. In this concern, Open Science commitment, rooted in the 2004 Messina Declaration and strengthened in the tenth anniversary of 2014 and the twentieth anniversary of 2024, is realized through funding open research, nurturing early-career researchers, and actively participating in global scientific discourse. To foster an open science culture, the University has established a dedicated commission, comprised of scientific representatives from each department, experts, and key stakeholders, to oversee and promote the implementation of open science practices.

The university's strategic plan prioritizes these principles, ensuring a future of inclusive, ethical, and impactful research. The university aims to promote research excellence through rigorous selection and qualitative evaluation of researchers, international talent scouting, and the implementation of a competitive funding system that values all disciplines. By initiating a peer-reviewed academic recruitment process, the university aims to enhance the quality of its research and favour a stimulating and proactive environment that promotes innovation and the growth of a dynamic and diverse scientific community.

Agreed COARA commitments

The University of Messina, having expressed interest in the Agreement in 2022, has developed the following Action Plan to fulfill its commitments within the ARRA timeline. In detail, in the following the agreed CoARA Commitments:

1. Recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication- based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organizations in research assessment
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organizational changes committed to
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

In this concern, a more structured approach implementing the CoARA agreement principles was defined in 2024. This strategy involves forming an Internal CoARA Committee (ICC) composed of the Vice-Rector for Research, Rector's Delegate for national and international projects and the Head of the Technical Coordination Unit for Data Analysis and Quality Assurance System.

Main Goals

Aligning to fulfill the CoARA commitments, the main goals are to establish a fair, qualitative, and data-driven academic career assessment system that aligns to global

best practices, actively addresses un-bias, promotes a culture of open research and data sharing.

To favor professional department development towards inclusive research evaluation supported by responsible use of qualitative and quantitative indicators, avoiding inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication- based metrics.

Strategy

To establish a transparent, equitable, and evidence-based academic career assessment system, the following key points were considered in the strategy evolution:

Quality Assessment Framework:	The focus of this step is to develop a comprehensive framework that defines clear criteria for evaluating the academic staff performance at various level, including research, teaching, service, and professional development. Furthermore, the framework will be aligned with international best practices and relevant disciplinary standards preserving the quality assessment principles. The Internal CoARA Committee (ICC) will be involved in the development and validation of the framework.
Quantitative and Qualitative Metrics:	To comprehensively evaluate the academic staff performance, employ a balanced approach that incorporates both quantitative metrics (such as research publications, citations, grant acquisition, and student outcomes), and qualitative metrics (such as teaching effectiveness, mentorship, and knowledge transfer activities), using established notes and guidelines to assess the latter
Open Access and Data Sharing	To promote a culture of open science, we must encourage academic staff to publish their research in open-access journals and share their data openly, recognizing and rewarding their contributions to these initiatives. Implementing policies that support data management and preservation will further enhance our commitment to transparency, reproducibility, and accessibility of scientific knowledge.

bias mitigation	A comprehensive strategy to mitigate bias in academic career assessment systems requires the implementation of standardized, objective evaluation criteria, blind review processes, mentorship programs specifically tailored to equity, and transparent promotion policies that explicitly address issues of unconscious biases based on race, gender, age, or socio-economic status and ensure equitable opportunities for all.
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A not secondary purpose is to establish a transparent promotion and tenure process by developing clear guidelines and procedures for decision-making, ensuring fairness and objectivity through a rigorous evaluation of the academic staff performance, and involving the ICC to provide assessments, ultimately promoting a culture of academic excellence and accountability. On this concern, regular review and improvement are essential to maintain the efficacy of the academic career assessment system. By conducting periodic check, we can identify areas for enhancement, gather valuable feedback from department, students, and external stakeholders, and make necessary adjustments to ensure the system's continued relevance and effectiveness in evaluating academic careers.

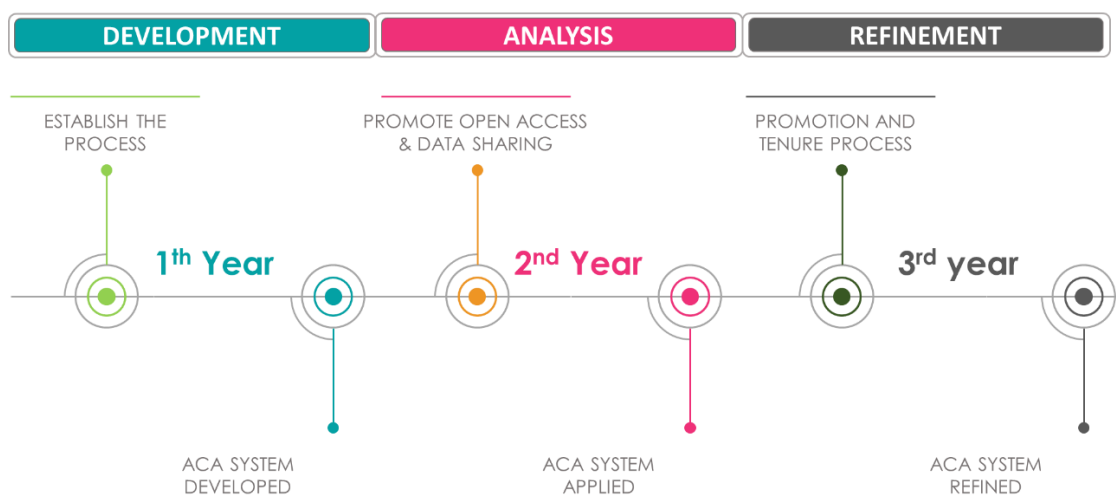
Timeline and resources

With a baseline of May 2025, a triennial schedule encompassing the subsequent three years is outlined below:

- Year 1 (May 2026): Develop the quality assessment framework, establish the peer review process, with unbiased strategies, on ACA implementing quantitative and qualitative metrics and trigger open access and data sharing strategies,
- Year 2 (May 2027): Launch the ACA peer review process for Department evaluations, promote open access and data sharing, and provide professional development opportunities.
- Year 3 (May 2028): Establish a transparent promotion and tenure process, conduct a review of the academic career assessment system, and make necessary adjustments.

The University has identified three key areas where it intends to fully embrace the CoARA commitments: early academic career development (1), open science and data sharing (2), preserving unbiased research evaluation (3). To effectuate the

organizational transformations pledged, the University will commit resources, employing already planned research funds, to restructuring research evaluation, while optimizing evaluation criteria; a roadmap review will be finalized in the middle of 2028, during which open science and research assessment criteria, tools, and processes will be developed (1st year) analyzed (2nd year) and refined (3rd year).



Understanding the diverse landscape of research fields and the different trajectories present in academic paths, the University is committed to giving fundamental importance to the assistance and recognition of emerging researchers in their careers, preserving equity in the whole procedures. Besides, to ensure the openness and accessibility of research results, the University will provide targeted research funding on the condition that output data is shared in FAIR repositories. Furthermore, by revising the reward-based funding system for early career individuals, the University aims to foster a supportive environment that promotes research and professional growth among young researchers preserving equity in the academic career assessment.

Transparent communication, training, and guidance on revised assessment criteria and processes will be disseminated to raise awareness and ensure their effective application, preserving equity. Progress on adhering to the principles and implementing these commitments will be communicated through public dissemination on the University website and via email to the entire academic community. The ICC will annually monitor changes in funding allocation criteria, and the CoARA roadmap will undergo review within the second and third year of its implementation.